

4-Part Team Assignment

Submissions due **Feb 13** | **Mar 06** | **Mar 30** | **Apr 02**

Intent

This series of tasks is for you to experience key stages in the innovation process using an innovation project originated by your team. Weekly lectures will set-up relevant background and suggested practices, followed immediately by implementation work by your team in class.

Process

Submissions

There are four submission stages: two interim submissions by the team for feedback ("Team 1" and "Team 2"), a final team submission ("Team 3"), and a final submission by individuals ("Team Contributions"). All submissions contribute to an aggregated mark for the whole project, given upon completion.

Individual & Team Components

Tasks are to be done by each team member. The team assignment final grade is weighted 50% for your individual work and 50% for the team's combined work.

- The team portion goes only to members who contribute to the project.
- Class meetings will have time reserved for team work. Extra work may be required beyond this time in class.
- Team members not present for team work, either in class or other times, will receive a mark in proportion to their participation.
- A team member who contributes nothing will receive a mark of 0.

Submission 1 | "Team 1" | Problem spaces & support

Deadline Feb 13 at 23:59 in its designated drop box

TASK: Meet as a team, consider multiple product spaces, and pick TWO you'd like to pursue for the rest of the term. One of these two will receive a go-ahead.

DELIVERABLES: Provide the deliverables listed below. These needn't be detailed. Use brief descriptions or point form as indicated.

1 - TWO PROBLEM SPACES WORTH PURSUING

For EACH of the two you propose, provide the following:

- **Problem Space (1-2 sentences)**

Describe the general area or type of solution you are considering. Make it the wider space, not a fully specified product. Stay broad enough to allow for different possible implementations after gaining more user input.

For example, "*TIME MANAGEMENT - A personal planning tool to keep track of academic and personal commitments.*" Not: "*An AI-powered calendar app with smart reminders and automatic scheduling.*" (This is too specific—you haven't validated that level of need yet.)

- **Problem Statement (single statement as below)**

Describe the problem/desire you want to satisfy in the space. Use this format:

<User> needs a way to <desire or goal> because <insight about why it matters>.

The problem statement must be solution-free. It should describe the unmet need, not a feature you imagine building. For example, "*A time-starved university student needs a way to feel in control of their academic and personal commitments because they want to avoid missing critical activities.*" Not: "*Students need a smart calendar because existing planners are hard to use.*" (Too vague, and "smart calendar" is a solution.)

- **Justification of Value (1-3 sentences)**

Explain why this problem is worth solving. For example, *how painful or frequent is this problem? What's at stake if it remains unsolved? Why don't existing solutions adequately address this? What's missing or broken?*

2 - CUSTOMER DISCOVERY PLAN

Anticipate three steps you will take to discover and empathize with ideal end users. Select from elements in the *Empathy Ladder* discussed in our class on January 27 (see reference slides for that day) or propose others that achieve the same objective to better understand users. At least one of these three must include a plan to do in-person interviews with someone you don't know, with each team member doing one. *Note: these are not to be done before submitting this stage, only the plan to execute your discovery plan after Submission 1 and before Submission 2.*

A strong Submission 1 will show two distinct, viable concepts with clear user focus and a realistic plan to learn more about your customers.

Identify your submission with the naming convention: **TEAM NAME_ submitted by _FirstName_LastName__DalhousieID(B0...)**

Submission 2 | "Team 2" | Prototype plan & support

Deadline Mar 06 at 23:59 in its designated drop box

TASK: Plan the prototype you will build and show as a MVP.

DELIVERABLES: Provide the deliverables listed below.

- **USER STORIES**

Provide two user stories from each of the members participating in your group (an "active member"). Note that the intent is for each active member to write two, and no member to write more than two. For example, a group with five active members will have $5 \times 2 = 10$ user stories; a group with three active members will have $3 \times 2 = 6$ user stories. Members not writing will be considered inactive and will not receive a grade for the assignment.

- Base at least one on the material you gathered in your customer discovery interview (see "Team 1").
- Write each user story from the point of view of an end-user, not a member of the development team.
- For each one, use the format "*As a <insert details of person>, I want to <insert capability or action> so that I can <insert the benefit or outcome>*"
- Try to provide a range of stories from the user's perspective in order to provide a fuller picture of the eventual product.
- Identify the writer for each user story.

- **MINIMUM VIABLE PRODUCT (MVP) PLAN**

What will make your product original and valuable to your future customer? What is the minimum viable functionality required to show this at the concept stage?

- From the broad set of user stories in #1, identify the subset of two or three you want to test in your MVP as the product's core value (these will be chosen from the collection above and identified by number).
- The choice of how many user stories to reflect in the MVP is yours; the priority is not the number but the extent they show the core value of the product.

- **STACK PLAN**

Your MVP should be a functional, interactive prototype (e.g., a clickable *Figma* or hosted web app) that allows users to navigate across multiple screens, interact with basic forms (e.g., text input, selections), and experience different interface states (e.g., hover effects, drop-downs, pop-ups). To reduce development time, the back-end may be a concierge-style manual process or calling an existing tool/API (e.g., *Google Forms* for intake, *Calendly* for scheduling, *Airtable* as a simple database). The MVP should support at least two complete user flows (e.g., user registration -> product selection; check out -> order confirmation) and be accessible via a shareable link.

- In 3-5 sentences, describe your technology choices and how they support delivering value to your target users. Put the emphasis on the customer rather than the code, showing you understand why this approach serves your ideal user.

- For any back-end functions to be performed manually or through external tools, briefly describe what the backend achieves and how you'll handle it during testing.

A strong Submission 2 will show that your team has talked to real potential users, translated those insights into specific user stories, and made deliberate choices about what to build first and why.

Identify your submission with the naming convention: **TEAM NAME_ submitted by _FirstName_LastName__DalhousieID(B0...)**

Submission 3 | "Team 3" | Product pitch & materials

Deadline Mar 30 at 23:59 in its designated drop box

TASK: Prepare and deliver a product pitch.

DELIVERABLES: Provide the items listed below.

- **LIVE PRODUCT PITCH (in class Mar 31)**

Present your MVP in a 5-8 minute investor-ready pitch. The pitch will clearly describe the customer's need, demonstrate an innovative solution, and highlight its originality by how it differs from presently available alternatives. In describing the value to potential users, the pitch will show a deep understanding of user habits and needs. During the Q&A session following the pitch, the team should be prepared to discuss all aspects of product development, including but not limited to

- (a) evidence of user needs,
- (b) evidence of user value (either quantitative or qualitative or both),
- (c) the technical choices made and their rationale,
- (d) examples of how the product differs from existing alternatives,
- (e) examples of measures to protect/preserve product value,
- (f) next steps required for further development,
- (g) what is being sought from potential investors ("the ask") and the reason, including use of funds.

The number of people presenting the pitch is up to the team. It can vary from 1 or 2 people to all team members. Team members who do not present, or have a smaller part in the pitch, will have a more prominent role during the Q&A.

- **COMPLETED LEAN CANVAS (Single page as PDF)**

Fill in each category with details specific to your innovation, either on the page provided or by replicating it. For projects with two-sided platforms, submit a Lean Canvas for each side. Split up the categories to complete, with all members participating. For each category, indicate who wrote that category by putting the writer's name in brackets at the end of that section. Do not use more than a single page.

- **PRESENTATION SLIDES** (PDF)
Include all slides used in the presentation, in the order presented. If using references, put them on the last page.
- **MVP LINK WITH WORKING URL** (Clickable)
The purpose is not to review the code but to see the functionality as demonstrated.
- **LIST OF TEAM MEMBERS** (PDF)

A strong pitch will demonstrate not just what you built, but why it matters to a specific user—and will leave the audience believing in the team behind it.

Identify your submission with the naming convention: **TEAM NAME_ submitted by _FirstName_LastName__DalhousieID(B0...)**

Submission 4 | "Team Contributions"

Deadline April 02 at 23:59 in its designated drop box

TASK: Portfolio of personal work on the project, with a reflection on your participation.

DELIVERABLES: Provide the items listed below. Put all items in a single PDF file with your name and BO number at the top of each page.

- **USER STORIES** (as previously submitted)
Copy and include the user stories you wrote that were included in Team 2 (see above).
- **LEAN CANVAS PORTIONS** (as previously submitted)
Copy and include the Lean Canvas portions you completed for the team document, including the headings.
- **TEAM TASKS COMPLETED**
Describe your role and contribution to product development throughout the term. Include specific tasks you undertook and how your efforts influenced the MVP your team is showing.
 - Present this as a job listing in a resume, with your role, and the project name
 - Provide four bullet points underneath showing your specific accomplishments for any aspect of product development.
- **PITCH REFLECTION**
Participate in the team presentation as either a presenter or question responder for the team. Then, briefly reflect on your role in the presentation in a written document.
 - Say what your presentation role was and why this was the one you took on
 - Describe one thing you thought you did well and would want to repeat in a future presentation

- Describe one practice you would like to try or improve in a future presentation.
- Make total length 75-150 words (for all elements above).

A strong Submission 4 will show multiple aspects contributed to the team project, with original personal insights about your presentation.

Identify your submission with the naming convention:

FirstName_LastName__DalhousieID(B0...)

ADDITIONAL GUIDELINES

FORMAT - For fonts, use 12-point Times or 11-point Arial. For the page, use 1-inch margins all around. Write in single-spaced sentences with a blank line between paragraphs. Put your team name on every page (including for the individual submission in Team 3.2).

SINGLE VERSION - Only one file will be opened for marking, the most recent one, unless you stipulate in an email to the instructor that another earlier file is to be marked. This also applies if more than one team member submits a file - only the most recent version will be opened for grading unless notification otherwise is sent by email.

GRADE - We will assess your team's submission for (a) providing all required elements in the form stipulated, and (b) making the various deliverables clear and free of errors.

- Qualitative evaluation will follow rubrics provided in advance for each submission (see attachments in each dropbox). The grade will reflect the extent these criteria are *met*, *mostly met*, *partially met*, or *not met*.
- Each team member will receive a letter grade, which will be unlocked for all team members who (a) participate in preparing this assignment and (b) participate in the final product presentation at the end of the term. Marks will be proportional if meetings or deliberables are missed.

GENERATIVE AI & ASSISTIVE SOFTWARE - The expectation for the team assignment is that the materials submitted will be your team's alone and original to the team. You may use generative software to help you think, but you will be accountable for every aspect of the work you submit. For greater certainty, unoriginality, possibilities of plagiarism, inaccuracies, mistakes, misstatements, copyright infringement, or other instances that degrade or misrepresent the submitted work will be attributed to each member of the team.

ACADEMIC STANDARDS - You must write in your own words; the material is to be from your perspective and must be original. Any instances that suggest copying from others will be examined closely as a possible academic offence. We may withhold your mark while a closer examination of your work occurs. Additional information about academic standards is in the course syllabus.